

Automatism

Freud, the founder of psychoanalysis, explored the unconscious minds of his patients using automatism, a form of free association that allowed the unconscious mind to 'speak'. Breton and others in his circle used the same technique in writing; jotting down whatever sprang into their minds without consciously thinking about it. Max Ernst's Surrealist collages were a form of visual automatism, in which he put together images cut from magazines, catalogues, books and other sources, to create unexpected images. André Masson, meanwhile, made automatic drawings in which he did not think about his marks, but simply allowed them to occur led by his unconscious mind.

Painter Joan Miró often starved himself in order to induce hallucinations as he worked: 'In 1925, I was drawing almost entirely from hallucinations. Hunger was a great source of these.' The resulting new language of art was later explored by the Abstract Expressionists in Action Paintings from the mid-1940s, and later became an important element in Art Informel and Tachism.



Arp, Untitled, c.1950